

CORE FORMULA

That's a real win. Especially after how long that process took. What was the best moment when you found out? -> That sounds like a relief. You carried that for a while. What changed once it landed? -> Nice - and not just nice, that reflects a lot of preparation. What part are you most proud of? -> That's worth enjoying. Want to tell me the headline version, or should we just mark it and keep moving? -> Good news. Glad that came through.

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

That's worth enjoying. What was the best part?

BEST FOR

- Someone shares good news, progress, relief, a win, a milestone, or positive feedback
- They sound proud but are trying not to boast
- A colleague mentions an achievement quickly and may move on too fast
- A friend or partner shares something that clearly took effort
- A digital update deserves more than a reaction emoji
- A team has a small win that should be noticed without overproducing a celebration

PHRASE BANK

Quick markers · Short, low-intensity

- "Good news. Glad for you."
- "That must be a relief."
- "Worth marking, even briefly."
- "Good. I'm glad that happened."
- "Nice one - that counts."
- "Glad that came through."

Warm / social · Friends and rapport

- "That's worth enjoying. What was the best part?"
- "I love that for you. What made it feel real?"
- "You sound quietly pleased. Want to tell me the good bit?"
- "That's not small. What are you most glad about?"
- "I want to give that a proper moment. What landed best?"
- "That must feel good after the wait."
- "That's a lovely thing to hear. What are you taking from it?"

Professional · Work and meetings

- "That's a strong result. What made the difference?"
- "That sounds like a real milestone. Which part took the most work?"
- "Worth noting: that landed because of a lot of hidden effort."
- "Good outcome. What should the team understand about what made it possible?"
- "That's useful signal. What worked?"
- "Solid result. Worth remembering what got it over the line."

Extension prompts · The one open question

- "What was the best part?"
- "What made it feel real?"

- "What made the difference?"
- "What are you most proud of?"
- "What should not get lost about this win?"
- "What was the moment you knew it had worked?"
- "What did you do differently this time?"

Digital / online · Texts and updates

- "This deserves more than a like - what was the best part?"
- "Huge. What was the moment you knew it had worked?"
- "Proper congrats. What are you most proud of?"
- "That's a good update. What made it possible?"
- "Genuinely glad to see this. What are you taking from it?"

Fragile or high-pressure · Mixed news, busy moments

- "Let's mark the win for ten seconds before the next fire. What worked?"
- "Before we move on, what part of this should not get lost?"
- "Sounds good, and maybe a little complicated. Want to keep it at the headline level?"
- "There's relief there, and maybe some other stuff too. What part do you want to mark?"
- "Quick marker: what finally shifted?"
- "I won't make it huge if you'd rather - but it is worth marking."

Recovery & autonomy release · Ease off, hand it back

- "No need to unpack it if you're already moving on."
- "We can just mark it and keep going."
- "Only if you want to say more: what was the best part?"
- "I may have made that bigger than you wanted. I just meant: good news."
- "No need to perform excitement. I'm simply glad it happened."
- "I jumped to my version. Back to yours - what mattered most?"
- "I'm over-questioning it. Let's just mark the win and move on."
- "No need for a big celebration. I just wanted to register that it counts."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Cool.

Better: That's great - what happened?

Best: That's a real win, especially after the uncertainty around it. What was the moment it actually felt real?

2. Weak: Must be nice.

Better: Congratulations, that sounds like a relief.

Best: I want to mark that properly: the result is good, and the effort behind it wasn't obvious to everyone. What part are you most proud of?

3. Weak: Anyway, about my thing...

Better: I'm glad that landed. You worked for it.

Best: Before we rush on, that deserves ten seconds. What should not get lost about this win?

DECISION TREE

If They shared a win, relief, or progress

Extend it: mark the good news, add one specific value, offer one short prompt.

"That's a real win. What was the best part?"

If No positive event was actually shared

Don't force it. Listen, validate, or ask a normal question instead.

If The win is private, mixed, or not public-safe

Use a low-intensity marker and stop.

"Good to hear. Glad for you."

If They seem energised and have room

Use a fuller extension prompt.

"What was the best part?"

If They're quietly pleased or in task mode

Use a smaller marker, then move on.

"Worth marking, even briefly."

If They don't elaborate, or you realise you overshot

Release the pressure or hand the moment back to them.

"No need to unpack it. I'm glad it happened."

SCENARIOS

A friend gets good news

Mark it, then invite the best part. — "That's worth enjoying. What was the best part of hearing it?"

A colleague solves a hard problem

Name the specific difficulty, then ask what moved it. — "Strong result, especially given the messy handoffs. What made it finally move?"

A partner shares relief

Acknowledge the load lifting, then ask what's lighter now. — "I'm glad that landed. What feels lighter now?"

A team milestone in a busy meeting

Protect ten seconds for it before the next agenda item. — "Before we move on, what should not get lost about this win?"

A modest person plays it down

Offer to keep it small while still marking it. — "I won't make it huge if you'd rather, but it's worth marking."

Good news with complexity

Name both sides, then let them choose the size. — "Sounds good, and maybe a little complicated. Want to share the good part or keep it light?"

WHEN NOT TO USE

- They signal privacy: "I don't want to make a thing of it."
- The news is mixed or fragile - attached to grief, guilt, survivor feelings, or uncertainty
- They are time-constrained or in task mode
- Public attention could embarrass them or create group envy
- Your enthusiasm would be louder than theirs
- The extension prompt would make them justify why the event matters

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Good-news markers

Take ten plain good-news statements and write one non-generic marker for each. Ban "nice" and "awesome" unless they're immediately followed by a specific detail.

Day 2 — Add the specific value

Return to each marker and add one reason the event matters: effort, timing, relief, courage, skill, persistence, trust, or meaning.

Day 3 — One-prompt discipline

Write exactly one extension prompt for each, then stop. The point is to feel where the interrogation reflex kicks in and hold it back.

Day 4 — Downshift practice

For five over-excited responses, write a calmer, lower-intensity alternative that still registers the win.

Day 5 — Recovery reps

Rehearse saying "No need to make it huge - I just wanted to mark it" out loud in a calm, unbothered tone until it sounds natural.

Day 6 — First live rep

In one real conversation, answer a good-news update with marker + specific detail + one optional prompt. Note whether

they opened up, stayed neutral, or downshifted.

Day 7 — A week of small wins

Catch one small positive update a day and extend it at the speaker's chosen size. Review which cue told you to continue, hold, or stop.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I notice the positive cue early enough?
- Did I name the good news specifically rather than generically?
- Did my prompt invite savour or meaning without demanding a performance?
- Did I keep the spotlight on them and match their celebration size?
- Did I stop after one extension prompt unless they clearly wanted more?
- Did I recover if I made it too big, or turned it into advice or comparison?